

Chat with Claude

Xivly user and test manual · the desktop app (macOS) · October 2026

Xivly can ask **Claude** about the paper you are reading. It runs **Claude Code** (the `c laude` command) on your Mac with your own login, so questions count against your Claude subscription and no API key is needed. This manual covers every part of it, in the order you would test them; section 9 is a checklist to tick off.

Screenshots come from the end-to-end tests (a one-page test paper and a stand-in for Claude), so the answers in them are short; the controls are the real ones.

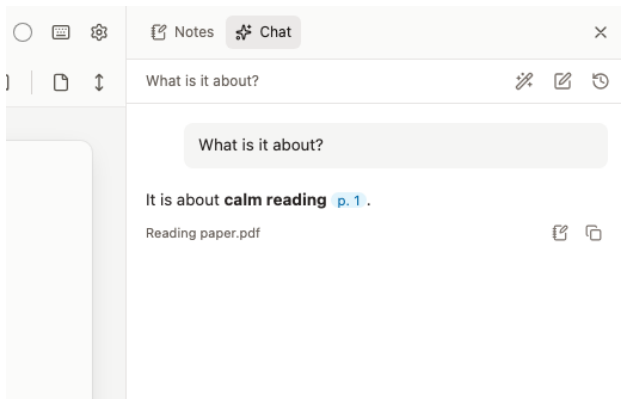
1. Before you start

- Install Claude Code and log in once in a terminal (`c laude`, then follow its login). Xivly never logs in for you and never reads Claude Code's login.
- Open **Settings (Cmd+,) › Claude**. The first row shows the version and path of the `c laude` Xivly found (through your login shell, as in Terminal), with **Check again**.
- **Path to claude**: only if it isn't found, e.g. `~/ . local/bin/c laude`.
- **Model**: Sonnet (the default, balanced), Opus (most capable) or Haiku (fastest). It applies to the next question.
- **Saved prompts** are edited below them (section 5).

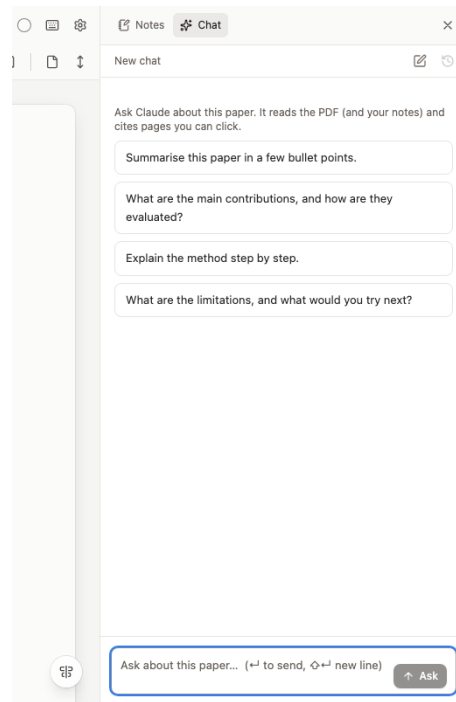
What Claude can do: it runs in the paper's own folder, with only the **Read** tool (it can read `paper . pdf`, `paper . j son` and your `notes . md`, nothing else), without your MCP servers or Claude Code settings. It is told to cite pages as `[ p . N ]`. It does not see your highlights or annotation notes (those are inside the PDF, as annotations); it does see your written notes.

2. Opening the chat and asking

Do	How
Open the chat	Cmd+Shift+E in a paper, or the Chat tab next to Notes in the right pane (Cmd+E shows or hides the pane). The question box gets the cursor.
Ask	Type, then Enter . Shift+Enter starts a new line. Or click Ask .
Watch it work	While Claude reads, a line under the answer says what it does (e.g. "Reading paper.pdf (pages 1-5)"); then the text streams in. When it is done it shows formatted: headings, lists, bold, code, maths.
Stop	Stop replaces Ask while it answers. What was written so far is kept, marked "Stopped".
Go to a cited page	Citations like p. 4 are blue chips: click one and the paper jumps there; Back to page N appears at the bottom of the paper to return.
Open a web link	Links in an answer open in your browser.
Usage	Hover the grey line under an answer: the API-price equivalent of the tokens it used (drawn from your subscription, not charged).



An answer: formatted, a **p. 1** chip, what Claude did, and the buttons under it (Add to notes, Copy; Insert as mind map when the answer is a list).



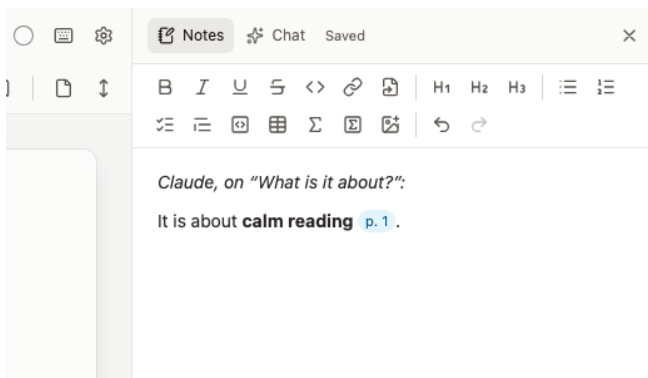
A new chat: a few saved prompts to start with, the question box at the bottom.

3. Conversations

- Each conversation is saved next to the paper and **continues**: a follow-up question (“and why?”) is answered with what came before, even after quitting Xivly.
- Opening the chat shows the paper’s **latest** conversation. Its title (the first question) is at the top.
- **New chat** (the pencil-in-square button) starts afresh; **Earlier chats** (the clock button) lists them all, newest first, to switch back to one.

4. Answers into your notes, or as a mind map

Button under an answer	What it does
Add to notes (notebook)	Puts the answer at the end of your notes, under a line in italics: <i>Claude, on</i> followed by your question. Formatting stays; [p. N] become the notes’ page chips (click to jump) and $\$...\$$ become formulas. A message offers Show to switch to the Notes tab.
Insert as mind map (network)	Only on answers with a list (e.g. from the “Mind map of the paper” prompt): the list becomes a mind map at the end of your notes, its page references as page links.
Copy	Copies the answer as Markdown.

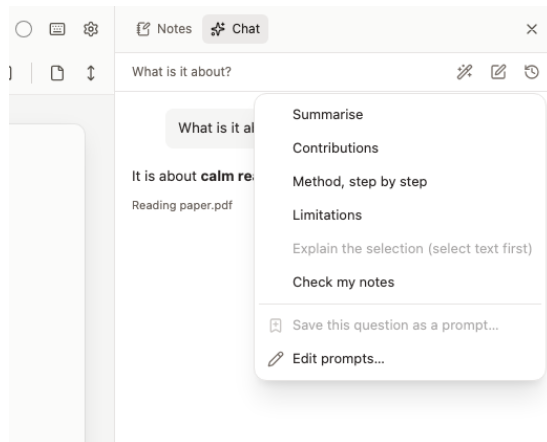


An answer added to the notes: under the question, its citation as a page chip.

5. Saved prompts

The **Saved prompts** button (the magic wand) at the top of the chat lists your prompts; choosing one asks it at once, filled in for this paper. A new chat also offers the first few as suggestions. They are kept for the whole library (they sync with it).

Prompt (defaults)	Asks
Summarise	a few bullet points
Contributions	main contributions, how evaluated
Method, step by step	the method, explained
Limitations	limitations, what next
Explain the selection	the selected passage, in plain terms
Check my notes	your notes: wrong or missing?
Mind map of the paper	a nested list (for a mind map)



The prompts menu. “Explain the selection” is off until text is selected in the paper.

Placeholders

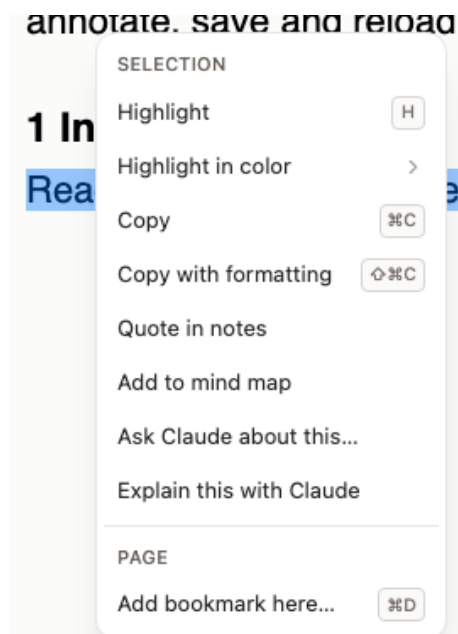
Write	Becomes
{{title}}, {{authors}}, {{year}}, {{abstract}}	the paper’s details
{{selection}}	the text selected in the paper (selected in the last 2 minutes also counts). A prompt that uses it is greyed out in the menu until something is selected.
{{notes}}	your notes on the paper (as Markdown)

Making and editing them

- Type a question, then **Saved prompts** › **Save this question as a prompt...**, and give it a name. It can use the placeholders.
- **Saved prompts** › **Edit prompts...** opens **Settings** › **Claude**: change a name or text (saved as you type), **Add** one, remove one (bin icon), or **Defaults** to go back to the list above.

6. Asking about a passage

- Select text in the paper and **right-click** it.
- **Ask Claude about this...**: the chat opens with the passage quoted, with its page, in the question box, and the cursor after it: type your question, then Enter.
- **Explain this with Claude**: asks at once for a plain explanation of the passage and how it fits the paper.
- Next to them: **Quote in notes** and **Add to mind map** (for the notes, no Claude).



Right-click on selected text.

7. Where things are kept

What	Where
Conversations	papers/<paper>/chats/<date>.json in the library folder (questions, answers, what Claude did, the session)
Saved prompts	.xivly/prompts.json in the library folder (only once edited; defaults until then)
Notes Claude reads	papers/<paper>/notes.md, rewritten on every save of the notes
Claude Code's own session	Claude Code keeps it in ~/.claude/projects/ (that is what lets a chat continue)
Settings (path, model)	this Mac only (Settings > Claude)

8. When something goes wrong

You see	Try
"Claude Code (the claude command) wasn't found"	Install it, or set Path to claude in Settings > Claude; the red message under the answer links there.
An error about logging in	Run c laude in a terminal and log in, then ask again.
The first answer takes a while	Normal: Claude reads the PDF first (the line under the answer says so). Follow-ups are quicker. Haiku is the fastest model.
"Stopped"	You pressed Stop (or the app closed mid-answer); ask again.
It doesn't know your highlights	It reads the PDF's text and your notes, not annotations. Quote what you need into the notes, or select it and use Ask Claude about this...
No Chat in the web version	Chat needs Claude Code on your Mac: desktop app only.

9. Test checklist

One line per feature, in order; tick when the result is as expected. Use a real paper.

#	Area	Do	Expect	OK
1	Setup	Settings > Claude	Version and path of claude shown.	☐
2	Setup	Path to claude: a wrong path, then clear it	An error; cleared, found again (Check again).	☐
3	Setup	Model: pick Haiku, ask; back to Sonnet	Haiku answers noticeably faster.	☐
4	Ask	In a paper: Cmd+Shift+E	Chat tab opens, cursor in the question box.	☐
5	Ask	Ask "What is this paper about?"	"Reading paper.pdf...", text streams, then shows formatted.	☐
6	Ask	Shift+Enter while typing	A new line; nothing sent.	☐
7	Ask	Click a p. N chip in an answer	The paper jumps to that page; Back to page N returns.	☐
8	Ask	Ask something long, press Stop	Answer ends, text so far kept, "Stopped".	☐
9	Ask	Hover the line under an answer	Usage in API-price terms.	☐
10	Chats	Ask a follow-up ("and why?")	Answered in the context of the previous answer.	☐
11	Chats	Quit Xivly, reopen the paper, open Chat	The conversation is there; a follow-up continues it.	☐
12	Chats	New chat; ask; then Earlier chats	Both listed (newest first); switching shows each.	☐
13	Chats	The paper folder's chats/	One .json per conversation.	☐
14	Prompts	Saved prompts > Summarise	Asked at once; a summary.	☐
15	Prompts	Explain the selection with nothing selected	Greyed out "(select text first)".	☐
16	Prompts	Select a passage, then Explain the selection	The passage is in the question asked; it is explained.	☐
17	Prompts	With notes written: Check my notes	Claude comments on your notes.	☐
18	Prompts	Type "List the figures of {{title}}", Save as prompt	In the menu; using it fills in the title.	☐
19	Prompts	Edit prompts...: rename, change text, Add, remove, Defaults	Each change is in the menu; Defaults restores the list.	☐
20	Passage	Right-click a selection > Ask Claude about this...	Passage and page in the box, cursor after it.	☐
21	Passage	Right-click a selection > Explain this with Claude	Asked at once, explained.	☐
22	Notes	Add to notes on an answer, then Show	At the end of the notes under "Claude, on ..."; chips jump.	☐
23	Notes	Copy on an answer; paste in a text editor	The answer as Markdown.	☐
24	Map	Saved prompts > Mind map of the paper > Insert as mind map	A mind map at the end of the notes, with page links.	☐
25	Errors	Path to claude: a wrong path, then ask	A red error under the answer, with a link to Settings > Claude.	☐